

WHY IT WORKS

Length is a signal of uncertainty — people who are confident in their position say it and stop. Unnecessary words force the listener to filter for the point, which creates cognitive friction and implies you do not know what your point is.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not terseness — the goal is density of meaning, not fewness of words for its own sake.
- Not skipping the warmth — a brief message can still carry care; it just carries it efficiently.
- It is respect for attention: saying what matters in the fewest words that still say it fully.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Reading their messages never feels like work.

Principle: Every unnecessary word taxes the reader — and the reader silently bills you for it.

What you gain

- Faster replies to everything you send
- Points that land at full strength, unburied
- More perceived confidence — length reads as doubt
- Time back, for you and everyone you write to
- Messages that get read instead of skimmed

Why most people fail at it

- They mistake word count for effort, and effort for respect.
- They soften every sentence until the point dissolves.
- They write to think, then send the thinking instead of the conclusion.
- They fear brevity will read as rude, so they pad — and bury the point instead.

CORE FORMULA

Cut words in half -> Lead with the point -> Earn elaboration

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Take whatever you were about to say and cut it in half. Lead with the most important word or sentence. Leave the rest.

BEST FOR

- Written communication — email, messages, reports
- Presentations with time constraints
- High-stakes verbal answers where clarity matters most
- Any communication where the reader or listener is busy

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Cut — Cut words in half

Take the draft — written or about to be spoken — and halve it. Remove throat-clearing, qualifiers, and the second version of every point. What survives is the message.

Padded: 'I just wanted to quickly reach out to see if perhaps you might have had a chance to look at...'

Cut: 'Have you had a chance to review the doc?'

2. Lead — Lead with the point

Put the most important sentence first — the ask, the answer, the decision. Everything else exists to support that sentence and follows it.

Buried: 'Some background before I get to my question...'

Led: 'My question: can we move the launch? Background below.'

3. Earn — Make elaboration opt-in

Offer the detail rather than delivering it. 'Happy to expand' costs one line; expanding uninvited costs the whole message its edge.

Forced: Three paragraphs of methodology nobody requested

Earned: 'Detail available if you want it — the headline stands alone.'

FIELD TIP

Draft long, send short.

Writing long is fine — it is how you find out what you think. The discipline is deleting the scaffolding before sending: cut the first paragraph, cut the qualifiers, and see if the message survives. It almost always does.

Situation: A five-paragraph email asking for a deadline extension.

Don't: Send all five paragraphs because deleting them feels wasteful.

Do: **'Requesting a one-week extension — the supplier data arrived late. New date: 14th. OK?'**

PHRASE BANK

Brevity Openers · Signalling you are being concise

- "Short version: ..."
- "In one sentence: ..."
- "The headline is..."
- "Two things: ..."
- "I will keep this brief: ..."
- "The core of it is..."
- "Bottom line: ..."

Cut Phrases · Catching and shortening

- "Actually — let me say that more simply."
- "I am over-explaining. The point is: ..."
- "Shorter version: ..."
- "Let me get to the point faster."
- "I will spare the context and say: ..."

Instant Answers · Complete in five words or fewer

- "Done."
- "Yes — by Thursday."
- "No blockers."
- "Agreed. Proceed."
- "On it."
- "Fixed. Deploying now."

Email Compression · Lines that replace paragraphs

- "Decision needed by Friday: option A or B. My recommendation: A."
- "Three updates, one line each, below."
- "TL;DR at the top; detail underneath for anyone who wants it."
- "No reply needed — this is just so you are not surprised later."
- "Everything below this line is optional reading."

Brief but Warm · Short without sounding cold

- "Short reply, warm intent: yes, gladly."
- "Keeping this brief because I know your day — the answer is yes."

- "Quick note just to say: you did well today."
- "One line before I run: thank you, properly."
- "Brevity is the schedule, not the sentiment."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs of context before the ask
Better: Here is the background — I need X.
Best: I need X by Y. Context in one sentence below.
2. Weak: Five-minute verbal explanation of a simple point
Better: I will try to keep this short...
Best: One sentence answer. Pause. Add one piece of context only if needed.
3. Weak: Email with no clear structure: all text, no hierarchy
Better: I have organised this into sections.
Best: Key point in bold at the top. Brief support below. Clear ask at the end.

DECISION TREE

If You are about to write a long email

Ask: can I say this in one paragraph? One sentence? Cut accordingly.

If You are about to give a long verbal answer

State the core in one sentence first. Offer detail after.

"The short answer is X. Happy to give you more context if useful."

If You are mid-sentence and realising it is too long

Stop. Restate in fewer words.

"Actually — let me cut that down. The point is simply: ..."

If You are being brief but losing important information

Add back only the essential context. Not everything that is interesting.

"The one piece of context that changes this is..."

SCENARIOS

Replying to a senior person's question in a meeting

One sentence answer. Then pause. — "Yes — the project is on track for Thursday."

Writing a message to someone with limited time

Lead with the ask. One line of context. Stop. — "I need your sign-off on X. Background below if useful."

Explaining a complex idea to a non-expert

Say the clearest version. Cut the jargon. — "The simplest way to say it is..."

Giving a status update in a meeting

Status first. Risk second. Ask third. Everything else is noise. — "On track. One risk: [name it]. No decisions needed from you right now."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: (3-minute explanation) ...and so essentially the answer would probably be to go with the first option, if that makes sense.

Manager: So just Option A?

You: Yes.

With the technique

You: Option A. Faster and lower risk. Happy to go deeper if needed.

Manager: That's all I need.

COMMON MISTAKES

Throat-clearing openers

Sounds like: 'I hope this finds you well. I just wanted to touch base to...'

Better: 'Quick question about Friday's deadline.'

Qualifier fog

Sounds like: 'I sort of think we should maybe possibly consider...'

Better: 'I think we should do X.'

Sending the thinking, not the conclusion

Sounds like: A message that wanders to its point the way you wandered to it

Better: Write it all, then send only the destination.

Brevity without hierarchy

Sounds like: Ten short lines with no signal of which one matters

Better: 'The key line is the first one. The rest is supporting.'

Cutting the warmth with the words

Sounds like: 'No.' (to a friend's heartfelt ask)

Better: 'Short answer with love: no — and I will explain tonight.'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People respond faster and more clearly to your communication.
- You are asked fewer 'so what is the point?' questions.
- Written communication takes less time to produce and read.
- Verbal answers land with more impact.

Signs to adjust

- Brevity is removing necessary context and causing confusion.
- You are being brief in situations that need warmth and nuance.
- Short answers sound abrupt or dismissive in tone.
- You are cutting words but adding them back through repetition.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In relationship-building contexts where brevity reads as cold or dismissive.
- When explaining complex technical topics to non-experts — completeness matters more than brevity.
- In emotional conversations where being concise can feel uncaring.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'Ignore my last three sentences; the first one was the point.'

- "Let me say that again in half the words."
- "I buried the question — it is this."
- "Ignore my last three sentences; the first one was the point."
- "That was my thinking out loud. The conclusion: X."
- "Too many words. Short version: X."
- "Brevity failed me there — let me try honesty at speed: X."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Busy-executive chain

Headline -> one supporting fact -> clear ask -> stop

The migration is done, a day early.

Zero data loss — checksums verified on all 41 tables.

One ask: approve the DNS switch for tonight.

That is everything.

Warm-brief chain

Name the brevity -> deliver the point -> keep the warmth -> exit

Thirty-second reply because I am between meetings.

Yes to Saturday, and yes I will bring the good coffee.

Longer catch-up soon — I have not forgotten.

Go smash today.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC003 — BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front

BLUF decides what comes first; Crisp Brevity decides how little of it there is.

TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline guards the ending — brevity is wasted if you keep adding after the stop.

TC024 — Lead With the Ask

Lead With the Ask is the request-shaped application of the same compression.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Word count audit

Take one email you wrote today and cut it by half. Notice what you removed. Was it necessary?

Day 2 — One sentence test

For every question you are asked today, attempt a one-sentence answer before elaborating.

Day 3 — Lead with the point

In three communications today, put the most important sentence first.

Day 4 — Earn the detail

After a brief answer, wait to be asked for more before adding it.

Day 5 — Cut filler

Identify and remove all filler phrases from one communication: 'as I mentioned', 'just to say', 'I wanted to reach out' etc.

Day 6 — Verbal brevity

In one meeting, aim to make your contributions 50% shorter than usual.

Day 7 — Calibration

Was your communication received better? Did brevity ever cost you something important? Where was it most effective?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I cut the communication by at least a third?
- Did I lead with the most important point?
- Did I offer elaboration rather than force it?
- Did I remove all filler phrases?
- Was the brevity appropriate for the context — not cold in a warm situation?
- Did I write in a way that respects the reader's time?
- Did the communication land more clearly as a result?